

(4) Baptist Churches

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Baptists Churches form a major Protestant denomination with approximately 40-45 million (2014 estimates) members worldwide. Most Baptists accept that the movement was founded by Anglican priest John Smyth (1570-1612 CE) who led a group of Separatists to Holland and in 1609 CE formed the first Baptist Church there.

John Smyth, Thomas Helwys and a group of 'Separatists' left England for Holland in early 17th century to avoid persecution when they wanted to purify Anglican Church from the remnants of non-biblical Roman Catholic practices. There in Holland they found refuge and formed first Baptist church. John Smyth first baptized himself with water and then the rest of the adults. Thomas Helwys led the group back to England and established the first Baptist Church in England in 1612 CE. Roger Williams (migrant from England) established the first Baptist Church in North America in 1638 CE.

This movement flourished in America and today there are approximately 33 million Baptists in United States out of the 45 million worldwide. Through Baptist missionary work the movement had spread to many other countries of the world. Today large number of Baptists are found in Nigeria (3.5 million), Democratic Republic of the Congo (2 million), India (2.5 million), Uganda (1.5 million), Brazil (1.8 million), and Myanmar (1 million).

Baptist churches operate according to the Congregational polity (church governance), giving autonomy to individual local churches. But the churches often associate with others in the same denominational group for mutual benefit and form large umbrella association such as the Southern Baptist Convention, National Baptist Convention USA, Conservative Baptist Association of America, American Baptist Churches USA to name a few.

Baptist Churches, as a of Protestant denomination share the basic beliefs of most Protestant denominations but differ in their belief that only adult (reject traditional infant baptism) believers should be baptized and that it should be done by full immersion in water.

In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of Baptist Churches and where there are differences with other Protestant denominations. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Baptists (like all other Protestant denominations) only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

(Only the unique features of Baptists Churches are discussed in this section)

THE CHURCH

Baptist Churches follow congregational polity in which each individual church is fully independent and governed autonomously, free from the direct control or hierarchy of any other institution.

~~Church structure is simple, plain and devoid of any statues and images.

THE CLERGY

The Baptist church leadership usually consists of one or more ordained, professional ministers/pastors, deacons and a board consisting elected members of the congregation.

Today some Baptist churches ordain woman in ministry while others (like Southern Baptist Convention 'SBC') do not. Same goes for homosexuals, as more conservative Baptist churches (like SBC) do not ordain homosexuals in ministry but some liberal ones do.

THE ORDINANCES (OR SACRAMENTS)

Baptists prefer to use the word "ordinance" as these practices are ordained by Christ to be observed by the church.

Baptism: Baptists do not baptize infants and children. They believe Baptism is only for believing adults. This ordinance is performed by full immersion in water (a key difference with other protestant denominations) after a person professes Jesus Christ as Lord and Savior and is symbolic of the cleansing or remission of his or her sins.

Lord's Supper: The Lord's Supper or the Holy communion is the only other ordinance Baptists observe as a symbolic act of obedience, whereby believers by the sacred use of bread and wine commemorate together the dying love of Jesus Christ. They deny any form of physical or spiritual presence of Christ in the bread and wine.

SEPARATION OF CHURCH AND STATE

Baptists also (like Anabaptist) believe in separation of Church and state. They believe church represents the community of believers and state (civil government) belongs to the world. Baptist churches are autonomous, hence there can be no outside interference in church (religious) affairs of

any outsider such as any secular power or the state. Therefore Baptist Churches reject the idea of an established or state church from early on.

STATUES AND IMAGES

Baptists object to use of religious statues and images.

CONTRACEPTION

Historically opposed contraception but in modern times many Baptists churches allow some sort of contraception.

ABORTION

Some Baptist churches allow abortion under certain circumstances and some (like SBC) do not allow abortion except in case of 'life of mother'.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

There is no unified position among Baptist churches on divorce and remarriage. While some allow divorce and remarriage under certain circumstances, others (like SBC) allow strictly only on biblical ground (adultery and desertion by unbeliever spouse).

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<http://www.religionfacts.com/baptists>,
<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Baptist>,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/christianity/subdivisions/baptist_1.shtml,
http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Baptist_Church,
<http://www.sbc.net/aboutus/basicbeliefs.asp>,
<http://www.abc-usa.org/10facts/>,
<http://www.nationalbaptist.com/about-us/what-we-believe.html>,
<http://www.baptisthistory.org/baptistorigins/baptistbeginnings.html>.